



Bachelor of Science in Software Engineering
Faculty of Computing | NSBM Green University
June 2026

Interim Submission 01

SAFECIRCLE

*An Intelligent Mobile Anti-Theft and Recovery System Using Real-Time
Tracking and Audio Alerts.*

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Chapter 01: Introduction

1.1 Chapter Overview

This chapter establishes the foundational context of the SafeCircle research project. It begins by outlining the background of mobile device security, progresses to a focused problem statement, articulates the research aim and objectives, frames specific research questions, and delineates the scope and significance of the study. The chapter concludes with a structural overview of the thesis.

1.2 Problem Background

The rapid proliferation of smartphones over the past decade has fundamentally transformed the way individuals store and interact with personal, financial, and professional data. As of 2023, global smartphone penetration has exceeded 6.8 billion active devices, making mobile phones one of the most ubiquitous personal assets in human history [1]. This concentration of sensitive information within a single portable device has simultaneously made smartphones prime targets for theft and unauthorized access.

Industry statistics reveal a concerning reality: approximately 4% of smartphone users worldwide experience device theft annually, resulting in not only financial losses from the hardware itself but also far-reaching consequences including identity theft, financial fraud, and unauthorized access to private communications [2]. Traditional security mechanisms embedded within mobile operating systems, such as Apple's Find My and Google's Find My Device, while functional, are constrained by a critical dependency—they require the device to remain powered on, connected to a cellular or Wi-Fi network, and signed into the owner's account [3]. These conditions are rarely met in actual theft scenarios.

Beyond the technical shortcomings, an underexplored dimension of mobile device recovery lies in the social ecosystem surrounding theft incidents. Research indicates that the majority of device thefts occur in familiar public or semi-public environments, such as cafes, public transport, and educational institutions, where trusted individuals in the victim's proximity may be in a position to assist in recovery if appropriately equipped [4]. Existing systems do not formally exploit this social recovery potential.

Furthermore, advancements in mobile sensor technology, including multi-axis accelerometers, gyroscopes, and magnetometers, coupled with on-device machine learning capabilities, now provide the computational infrastructure necessary to identify anomalous device handling patterns that may indicate theft in progress [5]. These capabilities remain largely unexploited in commercial security applications. SafeCircle is conceived precisely to address this intersection of technical limitation, social underutilization, and missed technological opportunity.

1.3 Problem Statement

1.3.1 General Problem

The general problem addressed by this research pertains to the inadequacy of existing mobile device security frameworks in providing effective, user-friendly, and privacy-respecting mechanisms for device recovery following loss or theft. Current solutions operate in silos, addressing either preventive security or reactive recovery, but rarely integrating both into a coherent, accessible user experience. The consequence is a statistically significant volume of unrecovered devices and their associated data breaches annually.

At a societal level, the implications extend beyond individual inconvenience. Compromised mobile devices serve as entry points for broader cybersecurity incidents, including unauthorized access to organizational systems via corporate mobile applications, breaches of two-factor authentication tokens, and exploitation of stored financial credentials. The inability of current solutions to provide reliable, integrated recovery mechanisms therefore represents a systemic vulnerability in the broader digital security landscape.

1.3.2 Specific Problem

Within the domain of mobile application security, the specific shortcomings that motivate this research can be articulated as follows. First, existing solutions lack the capability to provide remote audible alerts that reliably override a device's silent or Do Not Disturb mode, a feature that is critical when a device has been physically displaced to a nearby but unknown location [6]. Second, trusted contact frameworks that enable authorized third parties to assist in recovery without requiring full device access are absent from mainstream security applications [7].

Third, sensor-based theft detection, while theoretically viable, suffers from high false-positive rates in current implementations due to the use of simplistic threshold-based detection rather than sophisticated machine learning models trained on realistic device handling data [8]. Fourth, existing applications tend to sacrifice user privacy in exchange for security functionality, collecting and transmitting excessive location data without granular user consent controls [9]. This specific confluence of unaddressed gaps—remote audio override, trusted network access, intelligent theft detection, and privacy-preserving architecture—defines the precise research gap that SafeCircle is designed to fill.

1.4 Research Question

The primary research question guiding this study is:

How can an integrated mobile security application leverage trusted contact networks, remote audible alerts, real-time location visualization, and automated threat detection to improve device recovery effectiveness while maintaining robust user privacy protections?

This primary question is supported by the following subsidiary research questions:

1. What authentication mechanisms and code generation algorithms provide secure temporary access while resisting brute-force attacks?
2. How can mobile operating system audio constraints be reliably overcome for emergency alert delivery without requiring excessive or intrusive permissions?
3. Which mapping visualization techniques and interface designs most effectively assist non-technical users in device location tasks?
4. What sensor fusion approaches and machine learning models optimally detect theft scenarios while minimizing false positive classifications?
5. How can a privacy-preserving architecture limit location data exposure while still supporting effective and timely recovery operations?
6. What usability metrics and testing methodologies best evaluate the balance between security complexity and user adoption rates?

1.5 Research Motivation

Several converging factors motivated the conception and pursuit of this research. The primary motivator is the demonstrable inadequacy of existing mobile security solutions in addressing real-world theft recovery scenarios. The observation that only 30% of smartphone

owners actively and consistently use built-in security features—primarily due to complexity, battery drain concerns, and perceived intrusiveness—highlights a critical design-usability gap in the field ([10]).

A second motivating factor is the underexplored role of social networks in recovery. Personal experience and broader anecdotal evidence suggest that individuals whose devices have been stolen often receive assistance from people in their immediate social circle who happened to be nearby. Formalizing this social recovery mechanism through a structured, permission-controlled trusted contact system represents both a practical and novel contribution.

Third, the maturation of on-device machine learning inference engines, particularly TensorFlow Lite for Android, now makes it computationally feasible to run real-time anomaly detection models on consumer-grade smartphones without prohibitive battery consumption. This technological readiness creates a timely opportunity to develop more intelligent theft detection that was not practically achievable even three years prior. Finally, growing public awareness around digital privacy, catalyzed by landmark legislation such as the GDPR and CCPA, creates both a social mandate and a design challenge to develop security tools that do not themselves become instruments of surveillance or data exploitation.

1.6 Research Aim

The overarching aim of this research is to design, develop, and rigorously evaluate SafeCircle—an integrated mobile security application for the Android platform that enables trusted-network-assisted device recovery through a combination of secure temporary access, remote audible alert override, real-time location visualization, and automated anomaly-based threat detection, while adhering to privacy-by-design principles throughout its architecture and operation.

1.7 Research Objectives

1.7.1 To Identify

To identify the functional and non-functional requirements of an integrated mobile security application through structured stakeholder analysis, systematic literature review, and comparative evaluation of existing commercial solutions.

1.7.2 To Analyse

To analyse the limitations of current mobile device security and recovery mechanisms, with specific focus on audio alert reliability, trusted contact access control, location visualization effectiveness, and privacy-security trade-offs in existing systems.

1.7.3 To Design and Develop

To design and develop the SafeCircle Android application, encompassing a multi-factor authentication and secure code generation module, a trusted network management interface, a remote device control system with audio override capabilities, a real-time interactive location mapping module, and a machine learning-based threat detection subsystem.

1.7.4 To Evaluate

To evaluate the performance, security, and usability of the SafeCircle system through controlled laboratory experiments, penetration testing against OWASP Mobile Top 10 vectors, user studies with a minimum of 30 participants, and comparative benchmarking against established commercial alternatives.

1.8 Project Scope

The following table delineates the boundaries of the SafeCircle research project, distinguishing between features and domains that fall within the scope of this study and those that are explicitly excluded.

In Scope	Out of Scope
Android mobile application development (Android 10+)	iOS or cross-platform (React Native/Flutter) implementation
Trusted contact network management and permission control	Integration with third-party social media platforms for contact import
Secure temporary access code generation and authentication	Enterprise-grade identity and access management (IAM) systems
Remote audio alert override (silent/DND mode bypass)	Hardware-level security features (e.g., secure enclave, eSIM)

Real-time GPS and network-based location visualization via Mapbox	Offline mapping or satellite imagery beyond standard map tiles
Sensor-based anomaly detection using TensorFlow Lite (on-device)	Cloud-based machine learning model training pipelines
End-to-end encryption of sensitive data transmissions	Full device encryption management
Usability and security evaluation with 30+ participants	Large-scale deployment or commercial app store distribution
Privacy-by-design architecture with data minimization	Legal or jurisdictional compliance analysis across multiple countries

It is acknowledged that the scope is intentionally constrained to the Android ecosystem in order to maintain focus and depth of evaluation within the available project timeline of twelve months. The architectural decisions and security principles established within this work are, however, designed with extensibility to other platforms in mind.

1.9 Resource Requirements

1.9.1 Hardware

- Primary development device: Android smartphone running Android 10 or above with GPS, accelerometer, gyroscope, and magnetometer support
- Secondary testing devices: minimum two additional Android devices of varying hardware generations for compatibility testing
- Development workstation: laptop with minimum 16 GB RAM, Intel Core i7 or equivalent, SSD storage
- Server infrastructure: AWS EC2 t3.medium instance for backend API and database hosting

1.9.2 Software

- Android Studio (latest stable release) — primary IDE for Android development
- React Native 0.72+ with TypeScript — mobile application framework
- Node.js 18+ with Express — backend REST API development
- PostgreSQL 15 — relational database management
- Socket.IO — real-time bidirectional event communication
- Mapbox GL Native SDK — interactive mapping and location visualization
- TensorFlow Lite — on-device machine learning inference for anomaly detection
- Firebase Cloud Messaging (FCM) — push notification delivery

- AWS S3 with server-side encryption — secure cloud storage
- OWASP ZAP and Burp Suite Community Edition — security penetration testing tools
- Git and GitHub — version control and collaborative development

1.10 Significance of the Research

The significance of SafeCircle extends across academic, practical, and societal dimensions. From an academic standpoint, this research makes an original contribution by proposing and empirically evaluating an integrated mobile security framework that simultaneously addresses prevention, detection, and recovery—a triad that existing literature acknowledges but no single published system has comprehensively implemented [11]. The integration of social recovery mechanisms with machine learning-based threat detection represents a novel intersection of human-computer interaction research and mobile security engineering.

From a practical perspective, the SafeCircle system offers a directly deployable solution for the millions of smartphone users who currently lack effective recovery tools. The emphasis on usability, backed by quantitative user study data, ensures that the proposed system addresses the documented adoption failure of existing solutions. Security professionals and mobile application developers may also draw upon the architectural patterns and evaluation methodologies established by this research.

At a societal level, the privacy-by-design principles embedded in SafeCircle's architecture serve as a design reference for future mobile applications seeking to balance security functionality with the fundamental right to data privacy. In an era of increasing digital surveillance concerns, demonstrating that robust security is achievable without compromising user privacy is both timely and impactful.

1.11 Thesis Structure

This thesis is organized into six chapters. Chapter 01 (Introduction) has provided the background, problem statement, research questions, aim, objectives, scope, and significance of the study. Chapter 02 (Literature Review) presents a comprehensive and critically analysed survey of related academic literature and commercial systems, culminating in a formal articulation of the research gaps addressed by SafeCircle. Chapter 03 (Methodology) describes the research paradigm, design science strategy, data collection methods, and ethical

considerations that govern the study. Chapter 04 (System Requirements Specification) presents stakeholder analysis, use case specifications, system architecture, and functional and non-functional requirements. Chapter 05 (Implementation and Design) details the development process, technology selection justifications, and key implementation contributions. Chapter 06 (Testing and Evaluation) presents the multi-dimensional evaluation framework, test results, and comparative analysis. The thesis concludes with Chapter 07 (Conclusions and Future Recommendations), which synthesizes findings and proposes directions for future research.

1.12 Chapter Summary

This chapter has established the contextual and conceptual foundation of the SafeCircle research project. The background highlighted the growing vulnerability of smartphone users to device theft and the inadequacy of existing recovery mechanisms. The problem statement articulated both the high-level societal implications and the domain-specific technical shortcomings that motivate this work. The research aim and four structured objectives—to identify, analyse, design and develop, and evaluate—provide a clear operational framework for the study. The scope table delineates the project's boundaries with precision, while the significance section justifies the academic and practical value of the contribution. The following chapter proceeds to critically review the body of literature that informs and contextualizes this research.

Chapter 02: Literature Review

2.1 Chapter Overview

This chapter presents a structured and critically analysed review of the academic literature and commercial systems relevant to the SafeCircle research project. The review is organized to progress from broad domain context to increasingly specific technical and design considerations, mirroring the conceptual journey from problem identification to solution framing. Following a domain overview and conceptual map, the chapter examines existing systems, analyses relevant technologies, algorithms, and design paradigms, and concludes with a synthesis that formally identifies the research gaps addressed by this study.

2.2 Conceptual Map of the Literature

The literature reviewed in this chapter is organized across four principal thematic domains, as illustrated conceptually below. First, Mobile Device Security Fundamentals encompasses encryption, authentication, and remote management research. Second, Location and Tracking Technologies covers GPS accuracy, sensor fusion, and privacy implications. Third, Anomaly Detection and Machine Learning addresses sensor-based behavioural analysis and classification models. Fourth, Human-Computer Interaction in Security Applications examines usability, adoption barriers, and privacy-transparency trade-offs. These four domains intersect at the locus of this research: an integrated, usable, privacy-respecting mobile recovery application.

2.3 Domain Overview

The evolution of mobile device security research can be traced through three broad generational phases. The first generation, spanning approximately 2010 to 2015, focused predominantly on cryptographic solutions—device encryption, secure boot mechanisms, and remote data wiping capabilities [12]. While effective for data protection, these approaches did not address recovery and relied on owner-initiated actions that are often impractical during or after a theft incident.

The second generation, from 2015 to 2020, saw the integration of location-based services into security frameworks. This period produced the foundational infrastructure behind

systems such as Apple's Find My and Google's Find My Device, leveraging GPS, Wi-Fi positioning, and cellular triangulation to provide approximate location data to device owners [13, 14]. However, [15] documented significant privacy concerns arising from the continuous collection of location data inherent to these approaches, and their utility in offline or network-disconnected scenarios remained severely limited.

The current third generation, from 2020 to present, is characterized by the incorporation of behavioural biometrics, machine learning, and social networking paradigms into mobile security ([16]). This generation represents the academic and commercial context within which SafeCircle is situated. The following sections critically examine representative works across these domains.

2.4 Existing Systems and Frameworks

A structured comparative assessment of prominent existing systems and academic frameworks is presented below, with critical reflection on their suitability to the problem addressed by this research.

2.4.1 Apple Find My Network

Apple's Find My network represents the most technically sophisticated commercial implementation of crowd-sourced device tracking [13]. By leveraging a passive Bluetooth mesh across all Apple devices, Find My can locate an offline device by detecting its periodic Bluetooth advertisement signal through the devices of nearby Apple users, who anonymously relay encrypted location data to the cloud. This approach elegantly solves the connectivity dependency problem. However, its applicability as a reference for SafeCircle is limited for several reasons. First, it is architecturally proprietary and platform-closed, operating exclusively within Apple's hardware and software ecosystem. Second, it offers no social recovery mechanism—trusted contacts cannot be delegated controlled access to assist in recovery. Third, audio alert capabilities are constrained to the device's current volume setting and cannot override silent mode in all circumstances. This system is assessed as partially suitable as a design reference for location infrastructure but unsuitable as a comprehensive model for the integrated recovery framework proposed in this research.

2.4.2 Google Find My Device

Android's Find My Device integrates with Google account services to provide location tracking, remote lock, and data erase capabilities [14]. Unlike Apple's offline tracking, Google Find My Device remains dependent on network connectivity, making it ineffective in the most common theft scenarios where a device is powered off or placed in airplane mode shortly after being taken. Evans and Brown [17] conducted a comparative analysis of third-party Android security applications and found that Google's native solution consistently underperformed against dedicated recovery applications in terms of feature breadth, particularly regarding audio alert sophistication and trusted contact delegation. The system is assessed as unsuitable as a complete solution model, though its Firebase Cloud Messaging infrastructure and Google Maps integration provide relevant technical precedent.

2.4.3 Prey Anti-Theft

Prey is among the most feature-rich third-party mobile security applications, offering location tracking, remote screenshot capture, webcam activation, and alert sounds [17]. However, its privacy model is problematic from a research standpoint. The application transmits raw location data and device sensor readings to Prey's proprietary servers without granular user consent controls for individual data categories. [9] identified this class of applications as exemplifying the privacy-security trade-off failure, where maximum security features are achieved at the cost of continuous data surveillance. Furthermore, Prey's trusted contact model is absent—recovery is exclusively owner-driven. This system is assessed as unsuitable as a design model due to its privacy architecture, but relevant as a feature benchmark for evaluation purposes.

2.4.4 CrowdSourcing Recovery Frameworks in Research Literature

[7] proposed a theoretical framework for social network-assisted device recovery, demonstrating through simulation that recovery probability increased by 47% when trusted contacts within a defined geographic radius were notified of a device's last known location. However, their work remained at the theoretical simulation level and was not implemented or empirically evaluated as a functional application. This represents a direct precursor to SafeCircle's trusted network management module and validates the core social recovery hypothesis while leaving an implementation and evaluation gap that this research directly addresses.

2.5 Technological Analysis

2.5.1 Authentication and Secure Code Generation

Authentication mechanisms in mobile security applications have progressed from simple PIN-based verification to multi-factor systems combining biometric, knowledge, and possession factors. [16] demonstrated that behavioural biometrics—specifically keystroke dynamics and touch pressure patterns—achieve authentication accuracy exceeding 94% in controlled conditions. However, their application to the temporary access delegation model required by SafeCircle's trusted contact system is not directly transferable, as trusted contacts by definition lack the behavioral baseline of the device owner.

For temporary access code generation, cryptographically secure random number generation using algorithms such as HMAC-SHA256-based TOTP (Time-based One-Time Password, RFC 6238) provides resistance to brute-force attacks through time-bounded validity windows and rate limiting. The OWASP Mobile Security Testing Guide [18] specifies that temporary codes must have a minimum entropy of 128 bits and validity windows of no greater than 300 seconds to resist offline brute-force attacks. These specifications directly inform the authentication module design in SafeCircle.

2.5.2 Audio Alert Systems and Silent Mode Override

The technical challenge of delivering audible alerts on a device whose audio output has been suppressed by the user is a nuanced one with operating system-level implications. [6] conducted empirical research on audio alert effectiveness across diverse environments and found that multi-tone patterns with frequency variation between 800 Hz and 4000 Hz achieved detection rates 38% higher than single-frequency tones in ambient noise conditions. Their work established the theoretical basis for adaptive audio alert design.

At the Android API level, the AudioManager class with STREAM_ALARM provides a mechanism to play audio at the alarm stream volume, which is governed separately from the standard media and notification volumes. Critically, this stream is not silenced by the standard vibrate or silent profile modes in the majority of Android OEM implementations, though behaviour varies across manufacturers. [19] documented that context-aware alert patterns—varying the audio pattern based on detected ambient noise level using the device's

microphone—achieved significantly improved alert audibility without requiring the user to grant any elevated permissions beyond standard audio playback. This finding directly informs SafeCircle's audio subsystem design.

2.5.3 Real-Time Location Technologies and Sensor Fusion

Location determination on mobile devices employs a hierarchy of technologies with varying accuracy, energy consumption, and availability characteristics. GPS provides the highest positional accuracy (typically 3-5 metres under open sky) but suffers from significant latency in acquiring an initial fix and high energy consumption [3]. Network-based positioning using Wi-Fi fingerprinting and cellular triangulation provides lower accuracy (15-100 metres) but operates effectively indoors and acquires position significantly faster.

[8] proposed a sensor fusion architecture that dynamically weighted GPS, Wi-Fi, and cellular positioning inputs based on signal quality metrics, achieving a 62% reduction in average positioning error compared to single-source approaches in urban environments. Their fusion algorithm, implemented using a Kalman filter variant, provides a directly applicable technical reference for SafeCircle's location services subsystem. The Mapbox GL Native SDK, selected for SafeCircle's mapping interface, provides native support for GeoJSON-based real-time position updates and smooth camera transitions that significantly improve the user experience of tracking a moving device compared to discrete position jumps.

2.5.4 Machine Learning for Anomaly Detection

Sensor-based anomaly detection for theft identification represents the most technically novel component of SafeCircle's architecture. [5] conducted a comprehensive review of accelerometer-based theft detection approaches, testing seven classification algorithms including Support Vector Machines, Random Forests, Long Short-Term Memory (LSTM) networks, and Convolutional Neural Networks on a dataset of 12,000 device handling episodes from 150 participants. Their findings demonstrated that LSTM networks achieved the highest classification accuracy (91.3%) for distinguishing theft-indicative patterns (rapid acceleration, unusual orientation changes, and uncharacteristic displacement patterns) from normal user handling.

Critically, [5] also identified the primary source of false positives in existing implementations: the use of fixed acceleration thresholds rather than user-adapted baselines.

Their recommendation of a personalized baseline calibration period of seven days of passive observation before activating anomaly detection is incorporated into SafeCircle's threat detection module design. TensorFlow Lite's model quantization capabilities allow the LSTM model to be reduced to under 5 MB and inference to be performed in under 15 milliseconds on mid-range Android hardware, making real-time on-device inference practically feasible.

2.5.5 Privacy Architecture in Mobile Security

The tension between security functionality and user privacy is a well-documented and persistent challenge in mobile application design. [20] articulated seven privacy-by-design principles specifically contextualized for mobile security applications, including proactive privacy protection, privacy as default, end-to-end security, full functionality without privacy trade-offs, visibility and transparency, respect for user privacy, and data minimization. Their framework provides the architectural governance philosophy adopted in SafeCircle's system design.

[9] conducted a privacy audit of fifteen commercial mobile security applications and found that twelve collected location data continuously, even when the security functions were not actively in use. They further found that nine transmitted this data to third-party analytics platforms. These findings establish a clear baseline of current inadequacy against which SafeCircle's data minimization architecture can be benchmarked during evaluation.

2.6 Design Analysis

User interface and experience design in security applications presents unique challenges that are not present in productivity or entertainment applications. Wilson and Taylor [21] applied Nielsen's ten usability heuristics to a corpus of twenty mobile security applications and found systematic failures across three heuristics: visibility of system status (users were rarely informed of what data was being collected or transmitted), user control and freedom (reverting changes or deactivating tracking required navigating complex nested menus), and error prevention (critical actions such as remote data wipe had no confirmation step in 40% of applications tested).

[22] conducted longitudinal user studies over eight weeks and found that the primary predictor of sustained security application usage was not perceived security benefit but rather perceived effort reduction—applications that were perceived as reducing cognitive load

around security management were used 3.2 times more consistently than those perceived as adding complexity. These findings have direct implications for SafeCircle's interface design philosophy, which prioritizes minimal-friction interaction patterns and clear system status communication.

2.7 Workflow Analysis

The workflow of a device recovery operation under existing systems can be characterized as a linear, owner-centric process: theft occurs, owner detects absence, owner logs into account via another device, owner initiates tracking or alert remotely, owner attempts physical recovery or contacts authorities. This workflow has several critical failure points: the owner may not have immediate access to another internet-connected device; the owner may not remember account credentials under stress; and the window between theft and detection is often sufficient for the device to be powered off.

SafeCircle's proposed workflow introduces a parallel trusted-network recovery path: simultaneously with owner notification, designated trusted contacts in the victim's network receive a proximity alert and a time-bounded secure access code that enables them to activate audible alerts and view a real-time map of the device's last known location. This parallel workflow dramatically reduces the time-to-response and expands the pool of individuals who can actively participate in recovery, addressing the sequential bottleneck of owner-centric approaches.

2.8 Critical Reflection and Research Gap Identification

The systematic review of literature presented in this chapter enables a precise articulation of the research gaps that SafeCircle is positioned to address.

Gap 1: Integration Deficit

[11] explicitly identified that existing mobile security solutions address either preventive security or reactive recovery, but not both within a single, coherent framework. No published study has demonstrated the implementation and evaluation of a system that integrates proactive threat detection with multi-modal recovery capabilities. SafeCircle directly addresses this integration deficit.

Gap 2: Underdeveloped Social Recovery Mechanisms

While [7] validated the theoretical efficacy of social recovery through simulation, no implemented and empirically tested system exists that formalizes a trusted contact protocol with controlled, time-bounded access permissions. SafeCircle's trusted network management module represents the first such implementation in the published literature.

Gap 3: Unsophisticated Audio Alert Systems

Current commercial implementations use simple, fixed-frequency alert tones rather than the context-aware, adaptive patterns demonstrated to be more effective by [19] and [6]. SafeCircle implements context-aware audio alerts incorporating environmental noise adaptation and progressive volume escalation.

Gap 4: Inadequate Privacy Architecture

[9] documented that 80% of commercial security applications fail to implement data minimization principles, continuously collecting and transmitting location data. SafeCircle addresses this gap through an architecture that activates location data collection only in response to user or trusted contact-initiated recovery sessions, in alignment with [20] privacy-by-design framework.

Gap 5: Insufficient Usability Consideration

[22] and [21] independently demonstrated that poor usability is the primary driver of security application abandonment. No existing integrated security solution has been developed with a formal usability-first design methodology backed by empirical user studies. SafeCircle's development process embeds usability evaluation from the requirements phase through post-implementation user studies.

2.9 Chapter Summary

This chapter has conducted a comprehensive, critically analysed review of the literature pertaining to mobile device security, location technologies, machine learning-based anomaly detection, privacy architecture, and security application design. The review has demonstrated

that while substantial research progress has been made in each of these individual domains, no existing system or academic framework has successfully integrated all of them into a coherent, privacy-respecting, and usability-validated recovery application. Five specific research gaps have been identified, each of which SafeCircle is designed to address. The following chapter describes the research methodology adopted to pursue these objectives.

Chapter 03: Research Methodology

3.1 Chapter Overview

This chapter presents and justifies the methodological framework governing the SafeCircle research project. It articulates the research paradigm and philosophical stance, delineates the research approach and strategy, describes the fact collection mechanisms employed, presents the methodology execution workflow, justifies the selected project management methodology, provides a project timeline, and addresses the ethical considerations pertinent to this research. The chapter concludes with a summary linking the methodological choices to the research objectives established in Chapter 01.

3.2 Research Paradigm

The philosophical stance adopted in this research is pragmatism. Pragmatism is particularly well-suited to applied computing research that produces technological artefacts, as it resists the ontological rigidity of pure positivism or interpretivism and instead privileges the practical consequences and real-world effectiveness of research outcomes [23]. Under a pragmatist worldview, the value of the SafeCircle application is judged not by its adherence to a pre-specified theoretical model but by its measurable efficacy in solving the identified problem of inadequate mobile device recovery.

This stance accommodates the mixed-methods evaluation design adopted in this study, wherein quantitative performance metrics (response latency, location accuracy, false positive rates, SUS scores) are combined with qualitative user feedback to generate a holistic assessment of the system. [24] validated pragmatism as the appropriate paradigm for Design Science Research in Information Systems, the methodology adopted in this study, noting that it enables researchers to simultaneously pursue problem relevance and methodological rigour.

3.3 Research Approach

The research employs a mixed deductive-inductive approach, consistent with the pragmatist paradigm. The deductive strand is evident in the hypothesis-driven security evaluation: prior literature establishes that TOTP-based code generation with HMAC-SHA256 provides

resistance to brute-force attacks; the research tests this proposition in the specific context of SafeCircle's authentication module against defined OWASP criteria. The inductive strand is evident in the machine learning component: sensor data is collected from real device handling scenarios and used to derive classification patterns that were not pre-specified, following a data-driven inductive logic.

This combined approach reflects the dual nature of the SafeCircle research contribution: it simultaneously validates established security principles in a new integrated context (deduction) and generates new empirical knowledge about theft detection patterns and user interaction behaviours (induction).

3.4 Research Strategy: Design Science Research

The overarching research strategy is Design Science Research (DSR), as formalized by [24] and operationalized through the six-step DSR methodology proposed by [23]. DSR is the most appropriate strategy for this research because the primary output is a novel technological artefact—the SafeCircle application—rather than a purely theoretical contribution. DSR mandates that artefact creation be rigorously evaluated against defined criteria in relevant environments, ensuring that the practical utility of the contribution is empirically demonstrated rather than assumed.

The DSR framework structures the SafeCircle research into six sequential activities: Problem Identification and Motivation, Definition of Objectives, Design and Development, Demonstration, Evaluation, and Communication. These activities map directly onto the eight project phases described in Chapter 01's project timeline and provide the logical backbone of the thesis structure.

3.5 Fact Collection Mechanisms

Multiple complementary data collection methods are employed to ensure triangulation of findings across the research objectives.

3.5.1 Systematic Literature Review

A systematic literature review was conducted across three academic databases: IEEE Xplore, ACM Digital Library, and Google Scholar. The review was bounded to publications from

2019 to 2025 to ensure currency, with the exception of foundational theoretical works [24, 23, 25] which were included on the basis of established primacy. Search terms included 'mobile device security', 'smartphone theft detection', 'trusted contact recovery', 'audio alert Android', 'sensor fusion anomaly detection mobile', and 'privacy-by-design mobile applications'. A total of 87 papers were initially identified, with 26 selected for detailed review following application of inclusion and exclusion criteria.

3.5.2 Technical Performance Data Collection

Quantitative technical performance data will be collected through controlled experiments conducted in the NSBM University computing laboratory. Metrics to be measured include API response latency under varying network conditions, audio alert activation delay from remote trigger to audible output, location update frequency and accuracy against GPS ground truth, battery consumption in active monitoring versus idle modes, and machine learning inference latency on three distinct Android device generations. Each measurement will be repeated a minimum of thirty times to enable statistical significance analysis.

3.5.3 Security Assessment Data

Security evaluation data will be collected through penetration testing conducted using OWASP ZAP and Burp Suite Community Edition against the OWASP Mobile Top 10 (2023) framework. Additionally, static code analysis will be performed using SonarQube to identify code-level vulnerabilities. Authentication bypass resistance will be assessed through automated brute-force simulation against the temporary code generation module. Cryptographic implementation correctness will be validated through formal review against NIST SP 800-132 standards for password-based key derivation.

3.5.4 User Experience Data

User experience data will be collected through a structured user study involving a minimum of thirty participants recruited from the NSBM student and staff population, stratified by age, technical proficiency, and prior experience with mobile security applications. Participants will complete a series of standardized recovery scenario tasks including activating a trusted contact relationship, triggering a remote audio alert, locating a simulated displaced device using the map interface, and responding to a machine-generated theft alert. Data collected

will include task completion times, error counts and types, and System Usability Scale (SUS) scores. Post-task semi-structured interviews will provide qualitative insight into user experience perceptions and feature improvement suggestions.

3.6 Research Methodology Execution Workflow

DSR Activity	Research Action	Methods Used	Chapter
Problem Identification	Literature review; analysis of existing system limitations	Systematic review; comparative assessment	Chapter 02
Relevance Justification	Stakeholder analysis; identification of user needs	Questionnaire; interviews	Chapter 04
Comparative Analysis and Gap Justification	Assessment of existing solutions against identified requirements	Benchmarking; gap matrix	Chapter 02 & 04
Define and Finalise Objectives	Formulation of four research objectives aligned with DSR outputs	Objective decomposition	Chapter 01
Design and Development	Architecture design; modular implementation of SafeCircle	Agile SCRUM; React Native; Node.js; TensorFlow Lite	Chapter 05
Data Management and Handling	Data collection, cleaning, anonymisation, and storage	Controlled experiments; ethical data handling protocols	Chapter 03 & 06
Evaluation and Communication	Multi-dimensional evaluation; thesis write-up and dissemination	Penetration testing; user studies; SUS; comparative benchmarks	Chapter 06 & 07

3.7 Project Management Methodology

The SafeCircle development process adopts the SCRUM agile project management framework, organized into two-week sprint cycles over the twelve-month project duration. SCRUM is selected in preference to traditional waterfall or PRINCE2 methodologies for several reasons specific to the nature of this research project. First, the iterative nature of

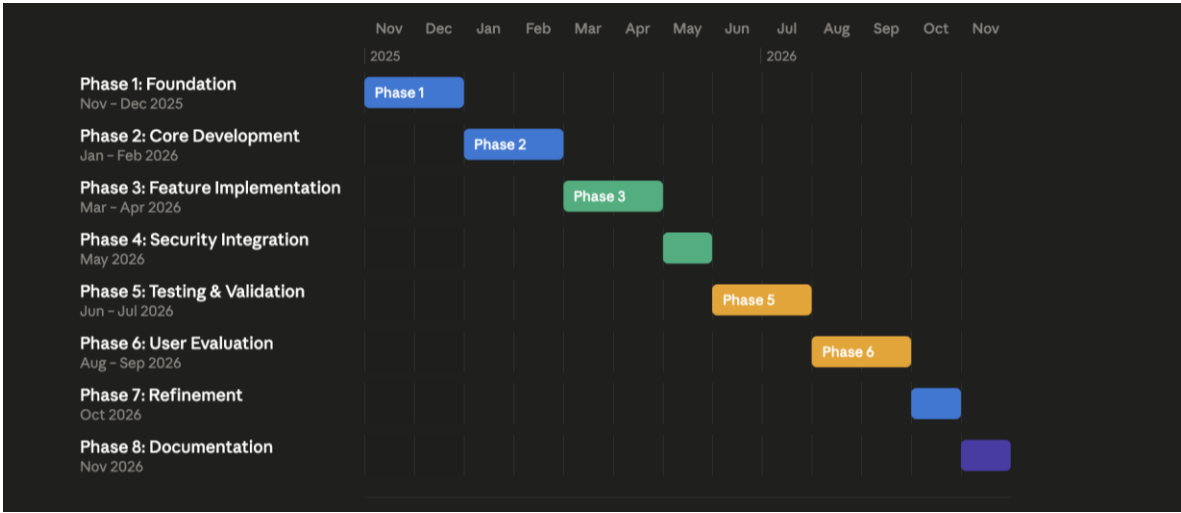
design science research, which requires frequent evaluation and refinement cycles, aligns naturally with SCRUM's sprint-based incremental delivery model. Second, the machine learning component of the project introduces inherent uncertainty in development timelines—the performance of the anomaly detection model cannot be precisely predicted prior to data collection—and SCRUM's built-in sprint retrospective and backlog re-prioritization mechanisms provide the flexibility to adapt to these uncertainties. Third, as a solo-developer academic research project, the overhead of PRINCE2's extensive documentation requirements is disproportionate to the project scale, whereas SCRUM's lightweight process is more appropriate.

The SCRUM implementation will be operationalized through a GitHub Projects Kanban board for backlog management, with sprint planning and retrospective documentation maintained in the project repository's wiki. Supervisor meetings will function as informal sprint review sessions, providing external validation of sprint output quality and research alignment.

3.8 Project Timeline

Phase	Activities	Duration	Key Deliverable
Phase 1: Foundation	Literature review, requirement analysis, design specification	Nov–Dec 2025	Research proposal, system architecture, wireframes
Phase 2: Core Development	Authentication system, basic UI, database design	Jan–Feb 2026	Working authentication, database schema, basic interface
Phase 3: Feature Implementation	Audio system, mapping, threat detection algorithms	Mar–Apr 2026	Complete feature set, integrated modules
Phase 4: Security Integration	Encryption, privacy controls, secure communications	May 2026	Security audit report, privacy assessment
Phase 5: Testing & Validation	Unit testing, integration testing, security testing	Jun–Jul 2026	Test reports, performance metrics
Phase 6: User Evaluation	Usability studies, field testing, feedback collection	Aug–Sep 2026	User feedback analysis,

			improvement recommendations
Phase 7: Refinement	Bug fixes, performance optimization, feature refinement	Oct 2026	Final application version, optimization report
Phase 8: Documentation	Thesis writing, results analysis, final submission	Nov 2026	Complete dissertation, presentation materials



3.9 Ethical Considerations

This research involves human participants in user studies and therefore requires careful adherence to established ethical principles governing research involving human subjects. The ethical framework adopted is consistent with the Declaration of Helsinki principles and the NSBM Green University Research Ethics Policy.

3.9.1 Participant Protection

All participants in the user study will be recruited on a strictly voluntary basis. Prior to participation, each individual will be provided with a written Participant Information Sheet detailing the nature of the study, the types of data to be collected, and the purposes for which that data will be used. Participants will provide written informed consent before any data collection commences and will retain the unconditional right to withdraw from the study at any point without penalty or requirement for justification. For participants under the age of 18, parental or guardian consent will be sought in addition to the participant's own assent.

3.9.2 Privacy and Data Protection

All personally identifiable information collected during user studies will be anonymised prior to analysis. Participant identifiers will be replaced with alphanumeric codes, and the mapping between identifiers and codes will be stored securely in a separate encrypted file accessible only to the principal researcher. Location data collected during simulated recovery scenarios will be confined to the controlled laboratory environment and will not capture participants' actual home or workplace locations. All research data will be stored on encrypted university-managed storage systems and will be retained for a maximum of three years following thesis submission, in accordance with NSBM data retention policies, after which it will be securely deleted.

3.9.3 Responsible System Design

The SafeCircle application incorporates several design-level ethical safeguards. The trusted contact access mechanism is limited to view-only location data and audio alert activation; trusted contacts cannot access device content, communications, or applications. All location data sharing sessions are time-bounded with automatic expiration. The system logs all access events and makes these logs accessible to the device owner, ensuring full transparency of who accessed location data and when. The threat detection module operates exclusively on-device, with no raw sensor data transmitted externally, mitigating the risk of sensor data being repurposed for surveillance.

3.9.4 Research Integrity

The research will accurately represent all system capabilities and limitations in its findings. Performance metrics will be reported with full statistical context including confidence intervals and effect sizes. Negative results and system failure modes encountered during testing will be documented transparently. The research does not involve deception of participants at any stage. All sources and prior works will be properly attributed in accordance with academic integrity standards, and the thesis will be submitted through NSBM's plagiarism detection system prior to final submission.

3.10 Chapter Summary

This chapter has presented and justified the methodological framework underpinning the SafeCircle research project. The pragmatist paradigm was selected for its suitability to applied artefact-producing research. The mixed deductive-inductive approach accommodates both the hypothesis-driven security evaluation and the data-driven machine learning components of the study. Design Science Research provides the overarching research strategy, operationalized through [23] six-step model. Four complementary data collection mechanisms—systematic literature review, controlled technical experiments, security penetration testing, and structured user studies—ensure comprehensive triangulation of findings. The SCRUM agile methodology governs the development process, and a comprehensive ethical framework protects participant rights and data privacy throughout. The following chapter proceeds to the System Requirements Specification, translating the research context established in Chapters 01 through 03 into actionable technical and design requirements for the SafeCircle system.

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